A Man Named Dave

By Dave Pelzer

DAVID: My father, Stephen Pelzer, he's here? I mean, he's okay and he's in this hospital on this floor. Right? *(blurting it out)*

STEVE: *(begins to reply, but raises a hand to his mouth as if to first collect his thoughts.)* Man, we've been waiting on you. Yeah, kid, your father's here, and . . . yeah, he's on this floor. But chill for a sec. There's a few things you need to know.

DAVID: *(rolling his eyes as if to say, Yeah, yeah, come on, out with it.)* So . . . *(nagging)* what's the deal? What happened? He fell down, broke an arm? What is it? When does he check out? *(Spins to the right, marches into the room where his father is. Takes a few seconds for his eyes to adjust. Mind is spinning. Slings his arm around his dad's shoulder to help him walk.)* Dad, are you all right? Are you okay?" *(His Father's eyes are blank. Eyes roll to whatever catches his attention for a split second before drifting off somewhere else. His body is trembling. He fights to stand up straight.)* Dad *(whispering gently)* . . . it's David. *(no reaction)* Dad *(firmer tone)* can you hear me? *(raspy exhale from Father)* Dad? Hey, Dad! Can you . . . do you hear me? It's me, David. Say something, anything. Dad? *(looking for the slightest response. Hoping he can communicate with his eyes -- No response.)*

STEVE: *(Firm, but gentle squeeze on David's right shoulder).* We need to talk.

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INTRODUCTION

Dave Pelzer was the victim of unbelievable child abuse. His mother denied him food and clothing, locked him in the basement, and told her son she could kill him any time she wanted to – and nearly did. And Dave's father? He never intervened.

By the time Dave was 12, the state had removed him from his home and placed him in foster care. But even years after he was rescued, his life remained a continual struggle. In this scene, Dave tries to reconnect with his dying father. A Man Named Dave by Dave Pelzer

DAVID: What's wrong with him? *(demanding, anxious)* What type of medication do you have him on? How come he doesn't recognize me? Is it the drugs? How long will it be until he gets better and gains some weight? When do you expect him to be released?

STEVE: Hey, man *(raising his hand),* give it a rest. Didn't your mother tell you? You don't know, do you?

DAVID: Know what? If I knew, I wouldn't be bugging you! *(Sarcastically)* Just tell me, what in the heck is going on? Please! *(begging)* I gotta know.

STEVE: *(leads him down the corridor, Steve searches for a more private setting. At the end of the hallway, he stops to offer David a chair. David refuses the chair and stands.)* It was about four months ago when your father was admitted –

DAVID: Four months! *(yelling)* Admitted? Admitted for what? Why didn't anybody call me? Why now?

STEVE: Please *(interjecting)* give me a chance. Your father. . . he wanted to keep things discreet. A lot of patients are like that. Anyway, it was only after we ran all the tests that our diagnosis was confirmed. David, your father has cancer. I'm afraid it's terminal. He's in the advanced stages. I'm sorry. *(reaching out for David's hands)* There is nothing we can do.

DAVID: Hang on! *(stepping away from his gesture)* What do you mean, terminal? I don't get it. . .

STEVE: David, *(deliberate, slow voice, gripping David by the shoulders)* your father . . . he's not going to make it.

DAVID: You mean. . . you're saying he's going to die? My dad is going to die? No way! *(shakes head in complete denial.)* Can't you give him a shot of something . . . or I thought there's some kind of chemo treatment. If it's money you need . . . just don't let him die. Not now. Please! *(begging, as if Steve alone decided the fate of his father)*

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STEVE: David, listen, chill for a sec. I don't know, no one knows exactly how long your father has, but, *(emphasizing this in a strong tone)* the thing I do know for certain is this: your father is not going to make it. And there is nothing, nothing, that you, I or anyone else can do about it. *(pausing)* David, *(taking David's hand)* I am sorry. I truly am.

DAVID: *(No energy. Thoughts are disjointed. Helpless.)* Four months? *(Incoherently)* You're telling me my dad's been here that long? How long has he been . . . like he is now? Why can't he talk? Is he doped up? I mean, he acts like he doesn't even recognize me . . . I don't, I just don't understand. *(stammering.)*

STEVE: Well *(sliding a chair next to David's)* your father checked in a few months ago. Since then his condition has rapidly deteriorated. The growth was primarily centered on the side of his neck, but has since spread to his throat. He is on medication, and under the circumstances, I'm sure you can understand why. That is the reason he lacks discernment. If we take him off the 'meds,' his understanding might improve, but the pain would be unbearable.

DAVID: So. . . he'll never be able to say anything again? Ever. . . ? *(voice trailing off)*

STEVE: That is correct. Not any longer. *(nodding his head)*

DAVID: So . . . what can I do? Why doesn't he look at me? Does he know, I mean, is he capable of knowing I'm even here?

STEVE: *(sighs)* For the most part, it's fifty-fifty at best. He seems more coherent in the morning but, for the most part, no more than a few minutes at a time. He's at the stage where he drifts off quite a bit. *(Beat)* I know it's a lot to deal with. *(shaking his head)* But first things first. Spend time with your father. That's priority one. I can walk you through the paperwork and all the other things you need to do when the time comes. For now, just spend time with your dad.

DAVID: But . . . I, ah, I don't know what to say. I mean, he doesn't even know that I'm with him.

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STEVE: Your father doesn't show it, but he's scared. He knows he's not going to make it. Anything you can do would mean the world to him. He's all alone in there. *(gently scolding)* You have to do this! Just . . . just reminisce about all those good times you spent together. Keep him 'up.' He'll know.

DAVID: *(cautiously walking back to his father's room; mockingly to himself)* *Yeah, all those good times. All my visits with Father probably amounted to less than ten, maybe twenty hours together.* *(Enters room . . . Tears swell in his eyes. Speaks to Father)* I, ah. . . I tried to write. I mean, I wrote. . . but I wasn't sure of your address. *(Shakes his head, stammering on)* I'm sorry. I truly am. I didn't know. I would have come sooner. I just didn't know.

(Turns away to compose himself. Doesn't want to lose it in front of his father. A few moments of silence, and then he remembers Steve's advice about keeping Father uplifted. Out of nowhere, a memory of Father and David springs to his mind, from when he was a preschooler.)

You may not remember, but when I was four, maybe five, all of us went to the Russian River . . . Early one evening, after dinner, you stepped out for a walk, and I tagged along behind you . . I snuck out and walked behind you, tracing your steps. I had those little Forest Ranger boots, and I tried to keep up while being as quiet as I could. I think I made it five, maybe ten feet away from the cabin, when you heard me. You spun around so fast I thought you were going to bite my head off, but you . . . *(stops for a second to smile at Father's face)* you simply extended your giant hand and scooped my fingers into yours. Then without a word, you let me walk with you.

I have to say, as a kid that was pretty cool. At the time, between Ron, Stan, and me, to be able to hog a few minutes alone with you, well, back then that was all I talked about after our walk. It was that summer when I knew that's where I wanted to live. The trees, the river, the smell, those precious moments with you,

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that's when I knew. Back then, with you, I was safe. Back then you were my superhero; you were my Superman. I know it sounds kinda dumb. *(scoffing)* But that was the only time you held my hand. When *you* wanted to be with *me*. *(stops for a moment to close his eyes.)*

When I was at the house, I remember all those times you'd come home from the fire station for just a few minutes to check in on me. Mother didn't know it, but I made sure I timed your arrival when I was washing the dishes so I could actually see you. Sometimes I got too far behind with my chores and . . . well, you know Mother . . . I paid the price when you were gone. I knew she'd never allow you to go down to the basement, so I'd wash the dishes over and over until I heard you open the front door. *(pauses to stare directly into Father's eyes.)*

You saved me. Even though it was only for a few seconds alone in the kitchen, it made all the difference. Sometimes if you brushed against me, I'd breathe in your Old Spice cologne. You were my invisible force field. I'm just sorry you, the boys – everyone – had to deal with so much stuff. I somehow thought I'd be able to make it up to you – to everyone.

You see, Dad, I knew. I always knew you came back to the house for me. And now, no matter what happens, I'm here for you. No matter what anybody says, I'll protect your honor. *(Beat)* As a kid, I was always proud of you being a fireman. You looked so cool in your dark blue uniform. It was then that I knew I wanted to be a fireman. Dad, Dad, do you. . . do . . . do you still have your badge? Your fireman's badge?

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(to audience) It's the only thing he has that showed what he did. After everything, it's all he has. Look, his eyes! The closet? You want me to look in the closet?

(searching his father's face for a reaction. Jumps from the bed and flings open the door. Eyes dart to the bottom of the closet. Opens the drawers. He finds nothing. Shakes his head. Picks up his father's coat. Pats it down. Yanks out a small leather casing. (Immediately father's breathing eases. He shuts his eyes as if in concentration. Lips quiver. Sounds trying to escape his mouth. Eyes lock onto David's)

I don't know! I don't know what you're trying to . . .*(suddenly feels the slightest sensation on his right hand. Glances down and sees father's bony fingers wrapped around his hand clutching the badge. He seals his son's hand around the black leather case.)* As God is my witness, I will protect and keep your badge. I will carry it as a sign of honor. *(Father's grip eases. He falls asleep) (David kisses his hand. Lays his hand on his chest.)*

STEVE: He'll be able to rest now. You've made him very happy. He told me months ago, when he checked in, that he wanted you to have it. Today was a good day for your father. A very good day.

DAVID: How do you – I mean, I don't know if he can understand me. If he could just talk

STEVE: He is talking. And you're learning to listen. It's hard, but as long as he knows you're there, beside him, that's all that matters.

TRANSITION: - ***These words are not in the text of the book:*** *I spent a few days at the hospital, talking to my dad and listening to him too. On the fourth day, when I arrived at the hospital, I met Steve at the entrance to Father's room.*

STEVE: *(extending his arm to block David from entering)* We need to talk. *(forced smile)* David, you need to understand . . . sometimes they can't . . . they won't go. . . until they know the ones they love will be fine. You . . . ah, get what I'm saying, David? He's in pain. You have to tell him you'll be fine. You have to let him go.

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You understand, right, David? He won't pass until you do this. Ease his suffering. It's the right thing for him. It's the proper thing to do. He won't pass until . . ."

DAVID: *(flees to the far end of the hall, where he finds a wooden bench. Clasps his hand together, he prays.)* I've never really asked you for much. And you know what I've been through. So, if you could grant me this . . . if there's no way that he can get better . . . then take him. Ease his pain and take my dad. Amen. *(wipes away his tears, clears his mind, and makes his way to Father's room.)*

I, ah, got. . . .some great news. *(lying)* The doctor says everything's gonna be fine. . . and that. . . they can have you up and outta here real soon. *(confidently peering into his father's face)* I didn't tell you this before, but I got a home on the Russian River. *(beaming)* It's got knotty pine walls and ceilings. A stone fireplace, your own room. It's always warm and sunny. It's really nice. It's got everything. It's on the river, and when the sun goes down, the water's as smooth as glass. At night you can smell the redwood trees . . . it's a piece of heaven, Dad. Heaven. You and I can live there. . . and go fishing. . . sit at the beach., or do anything we want. And in the summer . . . we can go to San Fran and catch a game at Candlestick – just like you always said we'd do. We can be like a real father and son. Just the two of us.

We made it, Dad! We really made it! Everything's gonna be fine. We can be together. . . and live at peace. We got a home, a real home. No more fighting, no more troubles, no one's gonna kick us out. We got it made! It's gonna be fine. You just relax and. . . I'll take care of you. . . .I'll take care of everything.

I've always been proud of you. You've always been my hero. And as your son, one day I will, I *will* make you proud. I always have and always will love you, Father.

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Now you relax. . . and I'll meet you at the river." *(Holds him behind his neck as delicately as possible. Kisses him on the forehead. Eases his head back onto the pillow.)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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